China's Role in UN Sanctions: Reassessing China's Adherence to the Liberal International Order with CEC Data

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Abstract

Mainstream sanctions literature has found that sanctions imposed by multiple cooperating states (multilateral sanctions) are more successful than sanctions imposed by one state (unilateral sanctions) when supported by international organizations. However, a crucial aspect of contemporary multilateral sanctions has been neglected: the cooperation of China with the sanctioning states. China's cooperation has high relevance for UN Security Council (UNSC) sanctions, one of the most prevalent types of multilateral sanctions, since it is one of only five permanent members, and is ambivalent towards the liberal international order that is followed by three of the other permanent members: the United States, the United Kingdom, and France. Using the Chinese Economic Coercion (CEC) data set (Zhang and Shanks, 2025) to source the data on China missing from the current research, this paper finds that China's adherence to the liberal international order, analyzed through voting similarity with the other permanent members of the UNSC, is nearly equally adherent for the security and human rights suborders. Overall, China's voting pattern is similar to that of the United States, the United Kingdom, and France, although it is notably more similar to that of Russia. China's non-support for UNSC sanctions has a modest negative effect on sanction success, with a fair degree of uncertainty due to the prevalence of supported sanctions among those with defined success ratings.

1 Introduction

Scholars disagree on whether the rise of China is a challenge to the liberal international order (LIO) or an insider working to reshape it according to its interests (Lake, 2020; Xinbo, 2018). China's support for United Nations Security Council (UNSC) sanctions are one crucial but understudied arena for adjudicating this debate. As the LIO's most coercive instrument, Chapter VII sanctions translate liberal commitments to collective security into legally binding obligations—but only to the extent that P5 politics allow. For Beijing, the UN is simultaneously ideationally attractive (sovereign equality) and instrumentally valuable (P5 status and veto), making the UNSC an especially revealing venue for observing whether and when China challenges or sustains the LIO (Fung, 2019; Wuthnow, 2013).

Existing scholarship on China's participation in economic sanctions biases heavily toward unilateral episodes, often reading them as evidence of deviation from liberal rules (Bohman, 2025; Zhang and Shanks, 2025; Zhang, 2024; Reilly, 2012). By contrast, China's participation in multilateral sanctions through the UNSC has been under-counted and under-theorized in the sanctions literature. We address this disconnect by leveraging the Chinese Economic Coercion (CEC) dataset (Zhang and Shanks, 2025), which adds extensive coverage of China's sanctions behavior and corrects systematic omissions of Chinese participation in UNSC measures, and by integrating it with CR-UNSC and DPPA veto records. China's involvement in other aspects of the UN Security Council has been studied extensively, but how its sanctions behavior compared to other P5 countries has not.

We make two contributions. First, we provide a descriptive account of when, how often, and in which issue areas China supports LIO-consistent UNSC sanctions by comparing PRC voting patterns to those of the P-3 and Russia. Second, we assess whether Chinese support, abstention, or opposition conditions the effectiveness of multilateral sanctions—linking a prominent theoretical debate about China and the LIO to observable outcomes in the UN's sanctions sub-order. This framework moves beyond inferences drawn from unilateral cases and offers a clearer test of China's adherence to, and influence over, the LIO where it has

real institutional teeth.

We find that China's UNSC voting largely adheres to the LIO and that China agrees with the P3 (the US, UK, and France) quite often on both security and human rights issues. Among the P3 states, China agrees most often with France, and least often with the US, but the difference is very small. China has seldom exercised its veto in UNSC sanctions but sometimes abstains from votes. China's non-support has a modest negative effect on UNSC sanction success.

The paper proceeds as follows. First is a review of existing scholarship on sanctions and the LIO, highlighting the theoretical and empirical gaps concerning China's role. Next is a description of the data and methodology, including the integration of the CEC, CR-UNSC, and DPPA datasets. Following this are the results on China's voting similarity to the P3 over the two suborders of the LIO, and on the importance of China's non-support for UNSC sanction success. We conclude by discussing how China conceives of the LIO, and when it diverges most from the LIO. After this, we discuss when China's non-support has the greatest effect on UNSC sanction success, and which aims of future research could arrive at valuable insights on China's adherence to the LIO.

2 Literature Review

2.1 UN Security Council Sanctions

The UNSC is particularly important in analyzing the intersection of multilateral sanctions and the Liberal International Order (LIO). It was designed by the victors of World War II to be the coercive backbone of a post-1945 collective security order that would be more durable than the League of Nations. At Dumbarton Oaks and San Francisco, the United States and its allies embedded collective security—legally binding decisions under Chapter VII, backed by enforcement—so the new order would have "teeth". To ensure great-power buy-in (and prevent a League of Nations repeat), the architects granted permanent seats and vetoes to

five states (the P5): the United States, United Kingdom, Soviet Union, Republic of China, and France. In principle, the bargain fused liberal rules (sovereign equality, non-aggression, human rights rhetoric) with great-power privilege as the price of stability. The UNSC was empowered to employ binding economic sanctions, originally institutionalized by the League of Nations as a supposedly "peaceful" alternative to war, as well as peacekeeping operations in response to "acts of aggression." (Mulder, 2022).

UNSC authority is socially constructed and thus contested. The UNSC embodies all four faces of power developed by Barnett and Finnemore (2004): it can coerce (sanctions/force), gatekeep through veto rules, stratify states (P5 vs. others), and define what counts as a "threat to peace." The legitimacy of the UNSC claims to universalism are central to sustaining the LIO's collective-security pillar—even as great-power politics can distort them.

The Cold War immediately complicated this vision. The UNSC's legitimacy came from universality, but its decision rule concentrated authority in rival superpowers. Vetoes and threatened vetoes often paralyzed coercive action, turning the UNSC into an arena of bloc politics rather than a neutral arbiter of collective security. The long stretches of UNSC deadlock during this period underscored the order's core contradiction: liberal procedures dependent on illiberal consent.

The transfer of the "China seat," held by the Republic of China (ROC) on Taiwan until 1971, to the communist People's Republic of China (PRC) only served to sharpen this core contradiction. Shrewd diplomacy by the PRC to normalize relations with UN members combined with the Cold War calculus by the Nixon administration in the US, which hoped to exploit the Sino-Soviet split to improve leverage over the USSR, paved the way for the PRC obtain P5 membership and veto power on the UNSC (Wuthnow, 2013).

After the Cold War, buoyed by "end of history" optimism, US policymakers sought to integrate Russia and China within a US-led Liberal International Order (LIO) by leveraging institutions like the UN, IMF, World Bank, and eventually the WTO. Johnston (2008) writes persuasively that, between 1980–2000, the PRC was partially socialized by security

institutions. He argues that changes in Beijing's willingness to comply with rules and its role conceptions cannot be explained by material incentives alone but instead can be explained by social influence and status concerns within institutional settings. Ikenberry (2008) argues that the LIO is enduring because it locks-in rising powers like China through multi-lateralism and creates powerful incentives to integrate rather than revise it.

2.2 Whither the Liberal International Order

According to the conventional telling, the Liberal International Order (LIO) was created and largely adhered to by the United States of America (the US), along with close allies in Europe such as the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland (the UK), and the French Republic (France) (Lake, 2020). These three most liberal permanent members of the UNSC (the P3) often cooperate to use the UNSC to impose multilateral sanctions upholding the LIO (Rees and Xu, 2024). In practice, the UNSC, arguably the LIO's most powerful security institution, is only as liberal as its least-liberal permanent members will allow. Crucially, the P3 needs to avoid a veto by either of the two other permanent members, Russia and China, to impose sanctions through the UNSC.

In recent years, many scholars have insisted that China's domestic authoritarianism must be incompatible with international liberalism, making it an inherently revisionist power within the LIO. They emphasize that because a liberal order enables the US to have influence over China, China will always seek to shift or destroy this kind of international order (Beckley and Brands, 2023; Huang, 2021; Mearsheimer, 2019). Indeed, if China can manage to export and reinforce autocracy abroad, it may be able to better prevent a wave of opposition to autocracy originating from abroad but reaching China (Beckley and Brands, 2023; Huang, 2021).

Other scholars caution against the narrative of China as a rising challenger to the LIO, as the overreliance on rhetorical assertions above careful empirical analysis has led to hasty and overgeneralized determinations (Chan and Hu, 2025). Instead, they have emphasized

that China tends to focus on pragmatism in adhering to the suborders of the LIO, which has more to do with selective adherence to the LIO than overall revisionism. They argue that China is therefore a state which is not fully a part of, but is arguably ambivalent to, the LIO (Johnston, 2019; Wuthnow, 2013; Fung, 2019).

2.3 China's Role in the UN Security Council

Since China became a member of the P5 in 1972, it has become much more accepting of the LIO, shifting from often abstaining on resolutions proposed by the P3 to endorsing them considerably more frequently. From 1972-1979, China mostly cast affirmative votes for UNSC resolutions, but abstained a large amount as well, engaging in frequent anti-hegemonic polemics especially against foreign military interventions by great powers into the third world. This is sensible considering that China had recently faced UN forces in the Korean War, and so habitually viewed UNSC interventions as tools to advance the US' geopolitical ambitions. Additionally, China had little incentive to align with the P3 at first due to its autarkic economy lacking major dependence on foreign powers (Wuthnow, 2013).

From 1980 onwards, however, China increasingly voted affirmatively more frequently than it abstained, thereby aligning considerably closer with the P3. At the same time, it engaged increasingly less often in polemics. This results from China's enhanced incentive to forge positive relations with the P3, as it was rapidly modernizing and opening itself up to trade especially with the US. China became much less opposed to foreign interventions, but remained wary of them. It supported some interventions, while still withholding support (usually with abstensions) from many others, particularly those over human rights abuses (Wuthnow, 2013). China's continued wariness of foreign interventions can be tied to its concerns over internal stability. Regime change becoming more acceptable elsewhere could eventually lead to regime change against the Chinese Communist Party (Fung, 2019).

Though China was anxious at the prospect of foreign interventions becoming more accepted to the point of possibly being targeted against them in the future regarding Tibet

or Taiwan, it had a desire for greater alignment with the P3, as well as Russia, to project unity among the P5 against attempts to add more permanent members to the UNSC. China also had a strong desire to be viewed as a "responsible great power," to relieve fears that it was a rising challenge to the LIO (Wuthnow, 2013). More generally, China's decision on whether to support sanctions greatly depends on how this pertains to its status. Higher status means greater rewards and lesser punishments from other states, enhancing China's influence. China views itself as both a developing state and a great power, and it is susceptible to cohesive peer pressure from other developing states or other great powers to support or not support sanctions. Since China sees the UNSC as the premier institution for matters concerning international security, China pays close attention to its status in the UNSC as viewed by developing states and great powers (Fung, 2019).

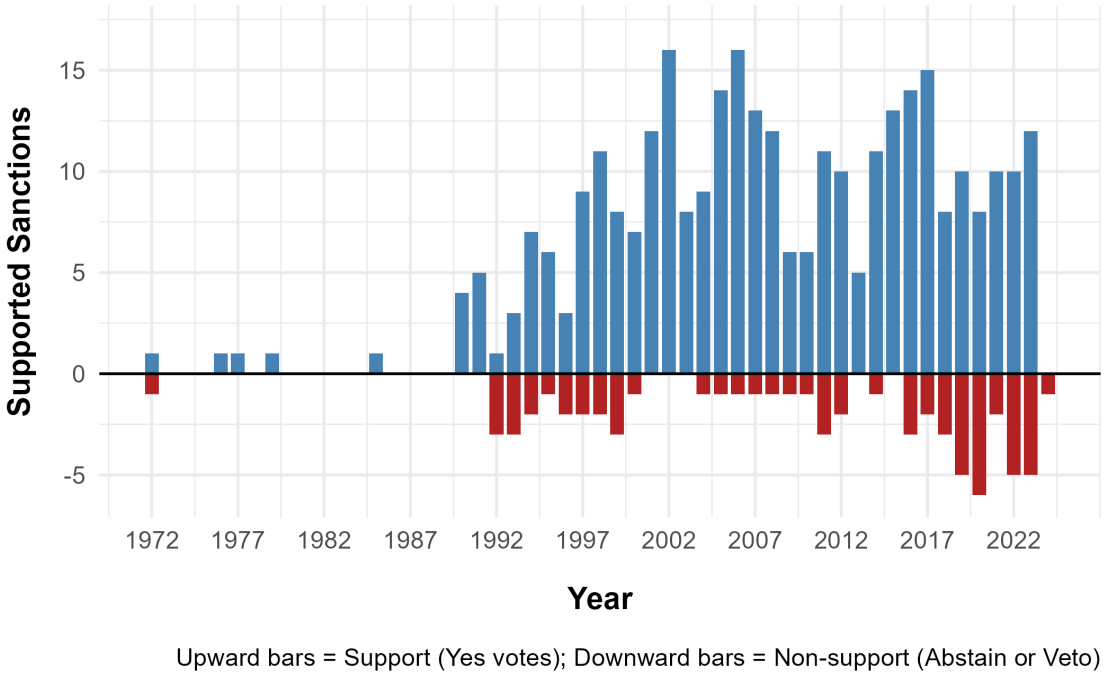

Figure 1: Timeline of China's Support and Non-support for UNSC Sanctions

It has often been argued that China's non-adherence to the LIO has been highest when its security and economic interests in pariah states such as Iraq, Sudan, Somalia, and Libya, have been threatened. For instance, China dampened sanctions against Sudan, and refused

to support multiple sanctions against Libya. China had a substantial security and economic interest in Sudan, and a substantial economic interest in Libya, both of which supplied it with crude oil. Accordingly, when sanctions were imposed on Côte d'Ivoire, a state China had no military interest and little economic interest in, China supported them. Russia, a state also wary of coercion by the P3, aligned with China in opposing many sanctions (Wuthnow, 2013). China does not consider Russia as a peer, however, as Russia loudly opposes the P3 while China carefully partners with the P3. China and Russia only ever align out of a shared opposition to great power intervention (Fung, 2019).

However, status is a separate and important determination of China's adherence to the LIO, and can override its specific material interests. For instance, when Colonel Gaddafi made a speech in 2011 comparing his repression in Libya to China's repression in the Tiananmen Square Massacre of 1989, China remembered how that incident greatly harmed its status. It felt that even abstention to subsequent sanctions against Gaddafi by the P3 would unduly harm its great power status, and developing states in the region supported foreign intervention as well. As a result, China voted in support of the sanctions against Libya contained in Resolution 1970, along with the rest of the P5. In contrast, four attempts by the P3 to sanction Syria from 2011-2014 ended in failure after China continued to veto them. Peer pressure from the P3 was ineffectual, as earlier in 2011 the P3 had enforced regime change against Gaddafi in Resolution 1973. China continued to reason that human rights abuses were not a sufficient justification for foreign interventions, especially those enforcing regime change (Fung, 2019).

If China tends to support UNSC sanctions along with the P3 more often when they pertain to certain suborders of the LIO, or more often when they pertain to particular states violating the LIO, this would enable a more nuanced interpretation of China's place in the LIO compared to the mainstream literature. Due to China's non-support having high relevance for UNSC sanctions, since as a member of the P5 China can veto a drafted resolution and thus prevent a sanction, the success rate of UNSC sanctions could vary significantly

depending on the presence of China's non-support. China's role in the UNSC must be considered before conclusions on the success of multilateral sanctions using UNSC sanction data can be made (Zhang and Shanks, 2025).

2.4 Effectiveness of Multilateral Sanctions

Sanctions can be defined as one or more states threatening to or imposing damages of trade relations between themselves and one or more targeted states, to persuade those targeted states to change some offensive policy or policies (Morgan et al., 2014). Much previous literature had been based on the assumption that sanctions are most successful when states cooperate in sanctioning others, since multiple states can command more resources and signal a broader opposition to the target state or states (Martin, 1990; Doxey, 1987; Mayall, 1984). Subsequent literature has challenged this assumption, evidencing the assertion that the sanctions which utilize the least cooperation tend to actually be the most successful. Cooperation between multiple sanctioning states can be counterproductive when some states free-ride on the efforts of others, or when increased coordination costs frustrate a cohesive effort (Drezner, 1999; Hufbauer et al., 1990). Despite this, multilateral sanctions may still have a greater potential for success. Later evidence has been provided for the notion that without international organizations encouraging multilateral cooperation, states succumb to internal pressure against cooperation, and renege on their commitments to other states (Drezner, 2000). More recent evidence has backed this notion and concluded that especially with the support of international organizations, multilateral sanctions are actually more effective (Bapat and Morgan, 2009).

The vast quantity of research on multilateral sanctions has been built upon the Threat and Imposition of Economic Sanctions (TIES) data set, arguably the most comprehensive data set to date regarding both unilateral and multilateral sanctions from 1945-2005. (Morgan et al., 2014). Another major data set is EUSANCT, which is partially based on data from TIES, and focuses on both unilateral and multilateral sanctions from 1989-2015 (Weber

and Schneider, 2022). Since the bulk of multilateral sanctions analyzed in these data sets are those by the EU and UN, it is unfortunate and surprising that their data on sanctions from the UNSC, which imposes multilateral sanctions on behalf of the UN, does not include voting data from the People's Republic of China, one of only five permanent members of the UNSC (the "P5") since 1972. The lack of data on China has arguably made conclusions on multilateral sanction success, particularly UNSC sanction success, less robust.

Studying Chinese involvement in multilateral sanctions is essential, as this is a domain where the LIO has real institutional "teeth" and where China's choices most directly adjudicate the "revisionist vs. stakeholder" debate. Yet, most of the research on Chinese sanctions as well as recent data collection efforts focuses on unilateral coercion, and reads those episodes as evidence of China's deviation from liberal rules (Reilly, 2012; Poh, 2020; Zhang, 2024; Bohman, 2025).

3 Research Design

This research note bridges a persistent disconnect in the literature: China features centrally in theoretical debates about the liberal international order, yet the empirical research on multilateral sanctions largely omits China's role. We compensate for the lack of UNSC voting data on China in TIES and EUSANCT using the Chinese Economic Coercion (CEC) dataset, which updates the TIES data set to include sanctions data on China, around 73 percent of which is not present in TIES or EUSANCT (Zhang and Shanks, 2025). The CEC dataset codes 135 sanctions episodes from 1949–2020 with China as sender using TIES v4 conventions for interoperability, and reveals that existing sanctions datasets systematically under-count China's involvement in multilateral UNSC sanctions. China is rarely listed as a sender (only once in EUSANCT; four times in TIES), even when France/UK are credited as secondary/tertiary senders on the same UNSC sanctions. This is despite the fact that since the Cold War, China has become the third-largest sender of multilateral sanctions (after

the U.S. and EU). China's participation in LIO-enforcing UNSC sanctions is larger than the mainstream sanctions literature suggests, yet this literature is silent on China's UNSC role and has not analyzed when China joins multilateral sanctions nor when its preferences diverge from those of the P3 or Russia. We analyze 57 UNSC sanctions resolutions on which the PRC voted: 55 yes, 2 abstentions (Iraq 1997; Sudan 2004) as well as 5 vetoes (Zimbabwe 2008; Syria 2012; Syria 2014; Syria 2017; DPRK 2022) of drafted sanctions legislation.

To answer the question, "How much do China's votes on UNSC sanctions align with the Liberal International Order?", we used the Corpus of Resolutions: UN Security Council (CR-UNSC dataset) (Fobbe et al., 2024) to source voting data for UNSC resolutions, and we used the "Security Council Data - Vetoes Since 1946" DPPA-SCVETOES dataset to source voting data for vetoed UNSC draft resolutions. We used resolutions and drafts from 1972-2024, since this year range starts with the first year that the People's Republic of China could veto UNSC drafts, and ends with the latest year of complete data.

We followed Morgan et al. (2014) and Zhang and Shanks (2025) in defining economic sanctions as threats or actions by states to limit or end economic relations with a target state for the purpose of convincing that state to change its policies. We also analyzed non-economic sanctions involving the threat or use of military force by member states of the UN to convince a target state to change its policies. We defined resolutions containing sanctions as impositions of sanctions, while vetoed drafts containing sanctions were defined as merely threats of sanctions, since the impositions of contained sanctions were prevented through vetoes. To analyze only resolutions and drafts containing sanctions, we analyzed only resolutions or drafts invoking Chapter VII of the United Nations Charter, since this gives the UNSC the authority to impose economic or non-economic sanctions.

We defined the Liberal International Order (LIO) as the system of international law reinforcing yet limiting state sovereignty, as it was created and is upheld mainly by the P3: the US, the UK, and France. We identified the two main non-economic suborders of the LIO as being the security order, concerned with maintaining state sovereignty while upholding

international law, and the human rights order, concerned with maintaining human dignity as outlined in The Universal Declaration of Human Rights adopted by the UN General Assembly. To find how much China's voting pattern aligned with the LIO, we used the CR-UNSC data over imposed sanctions and the DPPA-SCVETOES data over threatened sanctions to construct a measure of vote similarity based on that of Magu and Mateos (2017).

We defined the number of agreements between two states as the number of sanctions where either both states supported the sanction, or both states did not support the sanction. If a state supported the sanction, it voted in favor of it, and if a state did not support the sanction, it vetoed the sanction or abstained from voting. The number of disagreements between two states was similarly defined as the number of sanctions where one state supported the sanction while the other did not support the sanction. Vote similarity was calculated by subtracting disagreements from agreements between two states, and dividing this number by the total number of mutual votes, where both states voted or abstained on a sanction. This measure could range from -1 to 1, so it is not a percentage. In practice, all vote similarities were found to be between 0 and 1, with more agreements than disagreements.

This measure of how closely the voting pattern of one state resembles the voting pattern of another allowed us to make qualitative conclusions on how adherent China is to the LIO, and on which of the two suborders China diverges most from the order on. We defined China's level of adherence to the LIO according to how similar its voting patterns over the international law order and human rights order were to that of each of the P3, given these states' role in creating and historically perpetuating the LIO. Before we analyzed China's vote similarities to the two suborders of the LIO, we first observed the general vote similarity over all sanctions between the P5, to obtain a baseline measure of where China stands in relation to the other states. We also observed China's vote similarities regarding UNSC sanctions of the top five most-sanctioned countries, to the votes of the P3. Using the CR-UNSC and DPPA-SCVETOES datasets, we determined that Iraq, Sudan, Côte d'Ivoire, Somalia, and Libya are the five most-sanctioned countries. Imposed and threatened sanctions over Syria

were additionally analyzed as a special case for China's adherence to the LIO.

To answer the question, "How closely is China's non-support for a UNSC sanction correlated with sanction success/failure?", we used the CEC and EUSANCT datasets to analyze the available case-level data for UNSC sanctions, and compared this with the voting data for UNSC resolutions and vetoed UNSC draft resolutions from the CR-UNSC and DPPA-SCVETOES datasets, respectively. We used the 57 UNSC resolutions containing sanctions, and the 5 drafts containing sanctions which China vetoed, over the years 1990-2022. This year range is that of the most complete data for the UNSC sanctions China had the opportunity to vote on. 46 of these resolutions came from the CEC dataset, while 11 came from the EUSANCT dataset, after removing resolutions without votes, and observations which were not actually resolutions.

Following Morgan et al. (2014) and Zhang and Shanks (2025), we defined a sanction as successful when it convinced a target state to change its policies, and unsuccessful when it did not have this effect. This is the definition of success characterizing the success ratings of the CEC and EUSANCT cases. Vetoed drafts containing sanctions effectively threatened sanctions which were never imposed, while passed resolutions containing sanctions did impose sanctions which were either successful or unsuccessful. Therefore, resolutions containing sanctions had success ratings of "0" if their imposed sanctions were unsuccessful, and "1" if their imposed sanctions were successful. While there was no case data for vetoed resolutions, we gave all vetoed drafts success ratings of "0" to represent that their threatened sanctions were never imposed and so failed to have any effect. We therefore defined UNSC sanction success as a binary variable.

To create the independent dummy variable of China's non-support for a UNSC sanction, we took note of how China voted on resolutions containing sanctions. If China vetoed or abstained on a UNSC sanction, China did not support that sanction, and so the independent variable of China's non-support for that sanction would be represented with a "1". If China voted in favor of a UNSC sanction, China supported that sanction, and so the independent

variable for that sanction would be represented with a "0". The reason for defining the independent variable as non-support rather than support is to highlight the power of China's vetoes to make sanctions contained in drafted resolutions fail to change a target's behavior by definition. To find the correlation between China's non-support for UNSC sanctions and UNSC sanction success, we ran a logistic regression on the 62 sanctions (57 resolutions imposing sanctions and 5 drafts threatening sanctions) using UNSC sanction success as the dependent variable, and China's non-support for UNSC sanctions as the independent variable. To determine how well the independent variable explains the dependent variable, we used Tjur's R-squared.

4 Results

4.1 Do China's votes on UNSC sanctions align with the Liberal International Order?

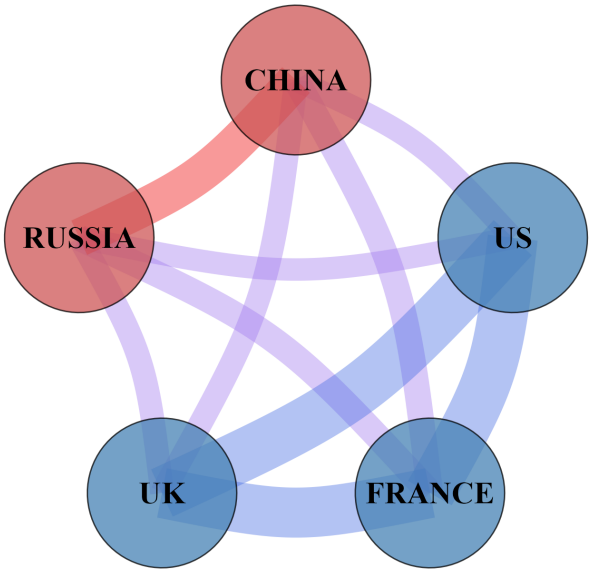

Figure 2: General Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members

In general, China's voting pattern is highly similar to that of the other states. China

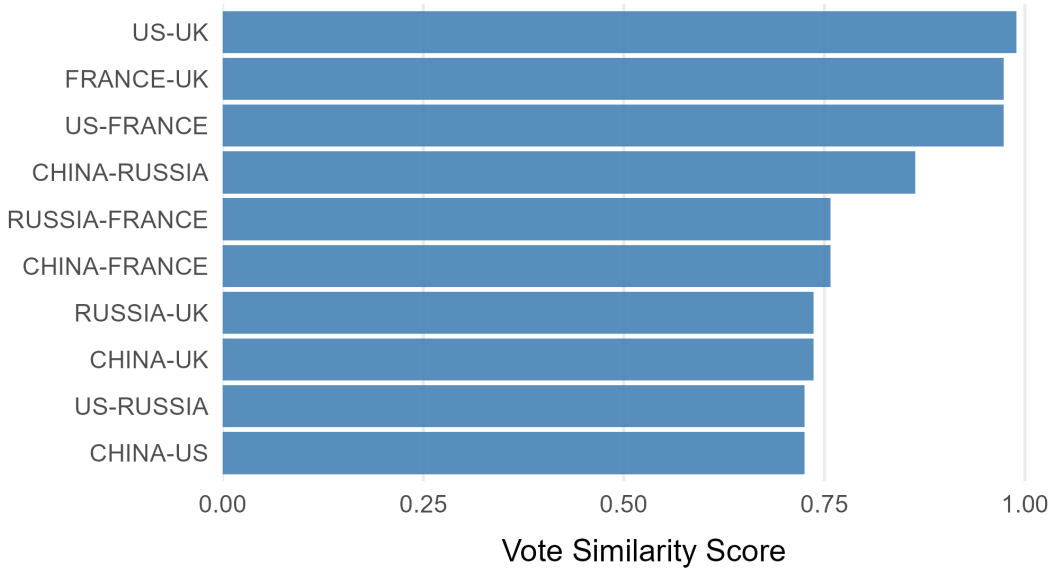

Figure 3: General Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members

is least similar to the US, then slightly more similar to the UK and France. China is most similar to Russia, but only by a modest amount compared with the US. As such, China is not actually very antagonistic in general to the interests of the P3 (the US, the UK, and France), preferring to agree with them over sanctioning or not sanctioning other states quite often. Notably, the three most liberal states (the P3) are most similar to each other, and the two least liberal states (China and Russia) are most similar to each other. The dissimilarity between the most liberal and least liberal states is fairly noticeable. However, the similarity between the most liberal states is higher than the corresponding similarity between the least liberal states. The US and France have the least similarity to each other among the most liberal states, but with very few disagreements, while China and Russia have slightly more disagreements. This shows that in general, the most liberal states agree more than the least liberal states.

The vote similarity between the veto members over sanctions upholding the Liberal International Order more or less follows the patterns of general vote similarity. For both the

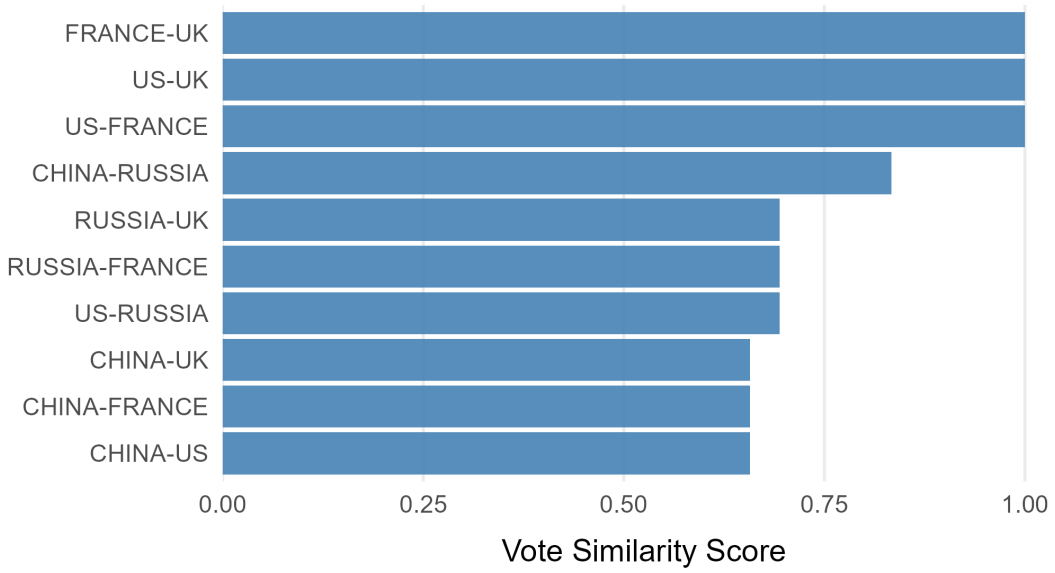

Figure 4: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Security

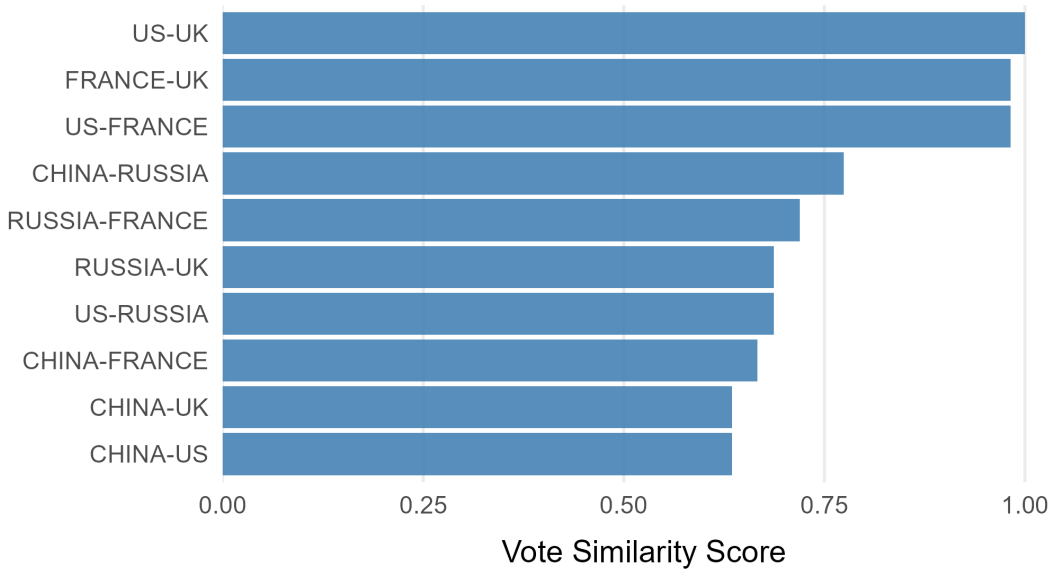

Figure 5: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Human Rights

security order and the human rights order, China is least similar to the US, then slightly more similar to the UK, slightly more similar to France, and most similar to Russia again by a modest amount compared with the US. The most liberal states are most similar to each other, while the least liberal states are most similar to each other, and the similarity between the most liberal states is higher than the corresponding similarity between the least liberal states. Regarding the security order, China's vote similarities to the other states are represented with almost identical scores when compared with its general vote similarities. Comparing the vote similarity over the human rights order with the vote similarity over the security order, there are minor but notable differences. China is more dissimilar to every other state over the human rights order when compared with the security order, albeit by only a small amount. In fact, the vote similarities between China and the most liberal states are the three lowest-scoring among the vote similarities for the 10 pairs of states. Meanwhile, the most liberal states are even more similar to each other under the human rights order compared with the security order, even as the least liberal states are less similar to each other. The highest vote similarity is that between the US and the UK, with no disagreements.

Compared with the vote similarity over the LIO, the vote similarity between the veto members over whether to sanction the five most-sanctioned countries has much more variance, but also retains many of the same patterns. China was again least similar to the US in how it voted over all of the most-sanctioned countries.

China and the US had the lowest similarity among the 10 pairs of states in voting over Sudan, Côte d'Ivoire, Somalia, and Libya, but Russia and the US were least similar to each other in voting over Iraq. For all of the most-sanctioned countries, the most liberal states are most similar to each other, while the least liberal states are most similar to each other, and the similarity between the most liberal states is higher than the corresponding similarity between the least liberal states.

This similarity between the most liberal and between the least liberal states was most pronounced for Somalia, where the US, the UK, and France all had no disagreements between

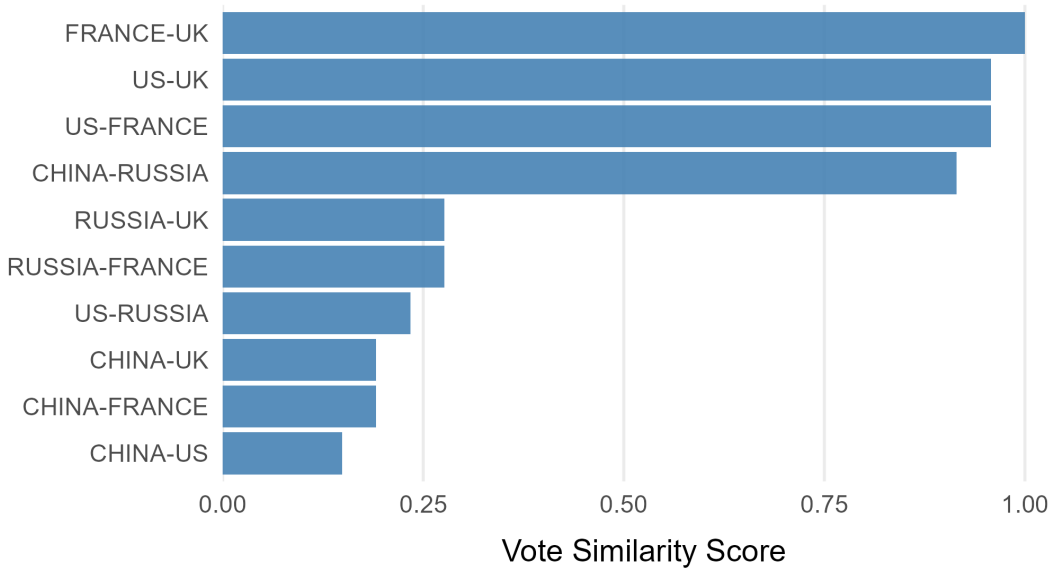

Figure 6: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Sudan

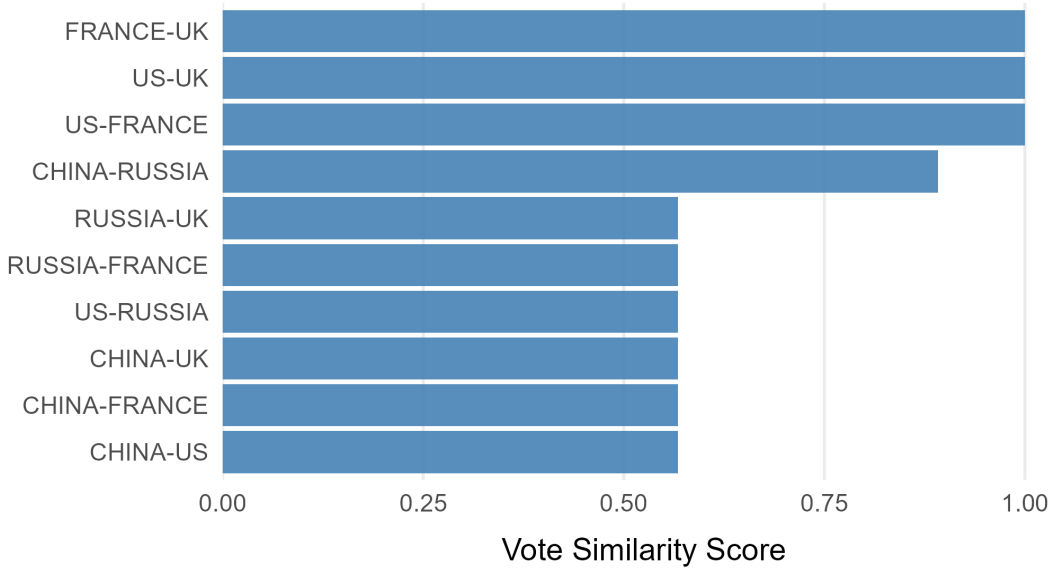

Figure 7: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Somalia

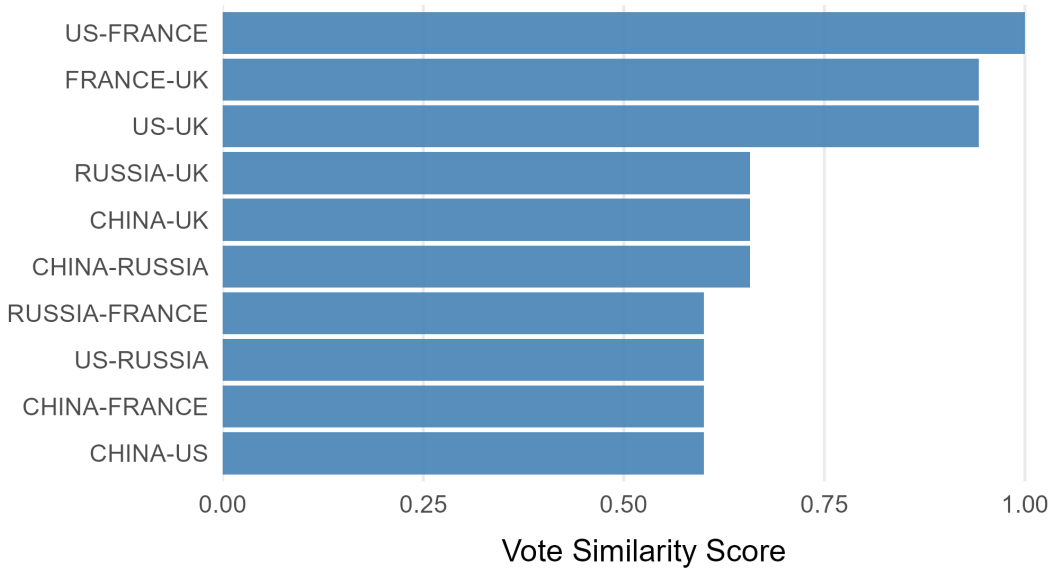

Figure 8: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Libya

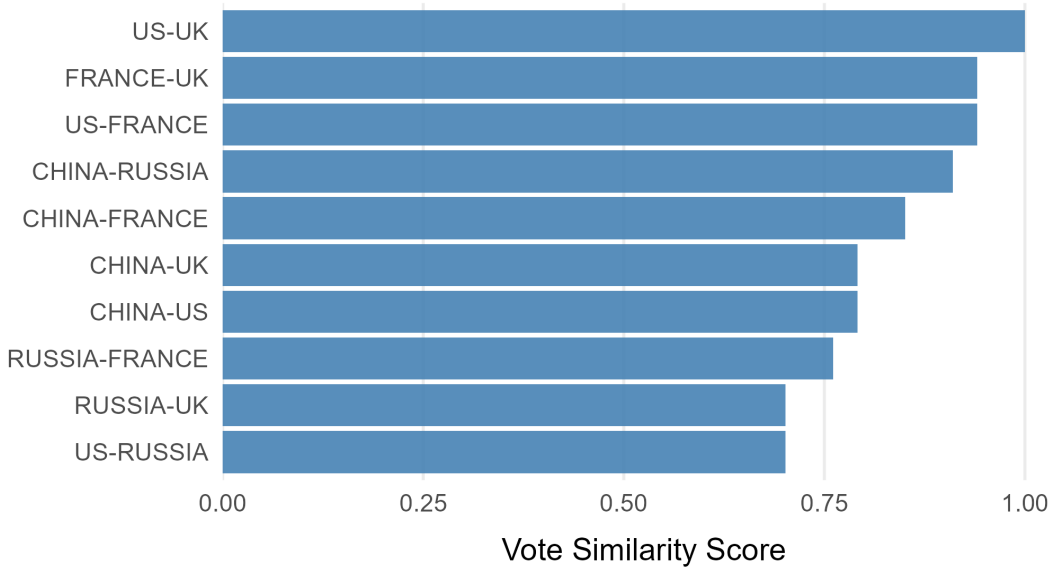

Figure 9: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Iraq

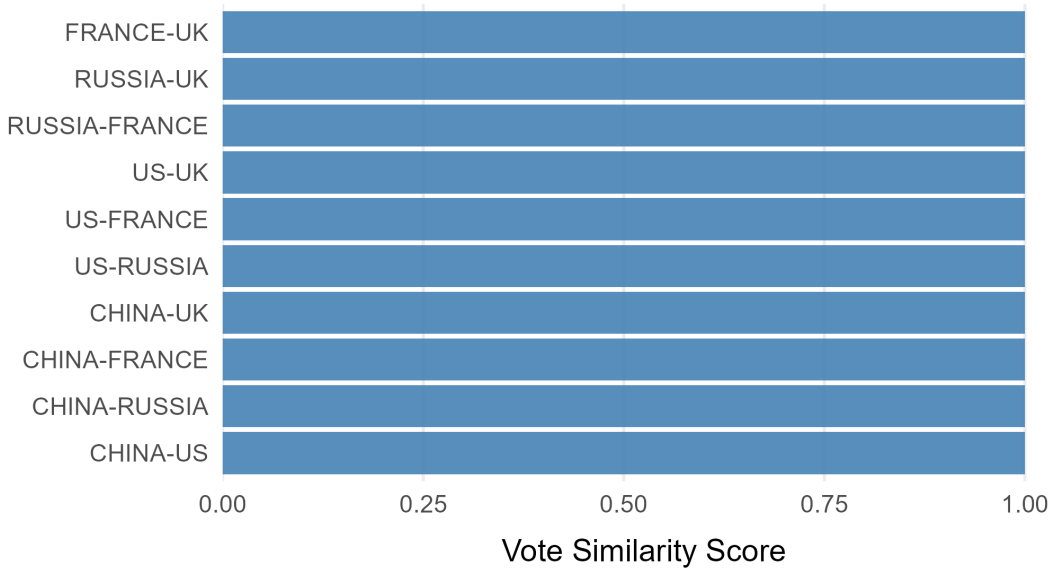

Figure 10: Voting Similarity Among P5 UNSC Members over Côté d'Ivoire

each other, while China and Russia had relatively few disagreements. The dissimilarity between the most liberal and least liberal states was most pronounced for Sudan, where the lowest similarity was between the US and China, with only a few more agreements than disagreements, and the highest similarity was between the UK and France, with no disagreements. There was also a fair level of dissimilarity between the most liberal and least liberal states over Somalia and Libya. The similarity between the most liberal and least liberal states was most pronounced for Côté d'Ivoire, where there were no disagreements among any of the P5 states.

There is one special case for China's vote similarities over sanctions upholding the Liberal International Order which modifies these results. China has vetoed 19 drafts since it became a veto member of the UNSC in 1972, and 10 of these were over Syria's violations of the security and/or human rights suborders from 2011 to 2020. Out of these 10 drafts, China vetoed 4 drafts threatening sanctions on Syria, and Russia vetoed with China each time, while the US, the UK, and France supported the sanctions. Earlier in 2005, one resolution

was passed which imposed sanctions on Syria, which China and every other veto member supported. As such, China is substantially dissimilar to each of the P3 states regarding Syria, but is perfectly similar to Russia.

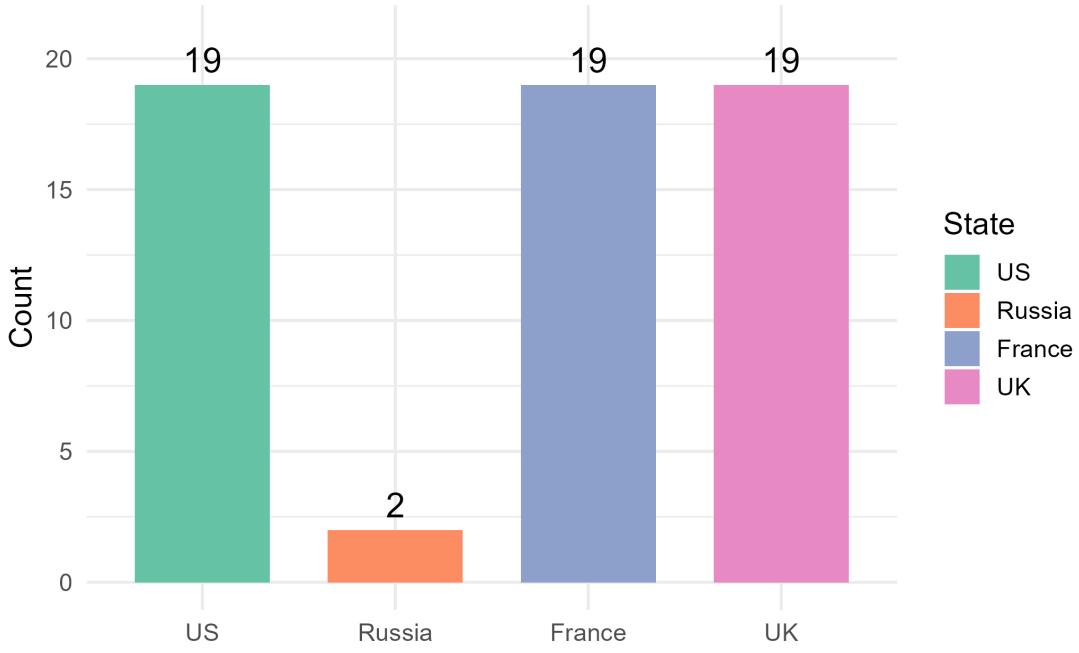

Figure 11: China's Vetoes Against Other P5 UNSC Members

It is also worth mentioning the veto similarity between China and the other veto members. Out of China's 19 vetoes from 1972-2024, all of these were against drafts which the US, the UK, and France all supported, and only two of these were against drafts which Russia supported. The two against Russia were against the admission of Bangladesh into the United Nations, and against sending military observers to verify the ceasefire ending the Guatemalan civil war. That China's vetoes were always in disagreement with the P3, and rarely in disagreement with Russia, shows China's closer similarity to Russia compared to the P3.

4.2 Does China's non-support for a UNSC sanction matter for sanction success?

The logistic regression used to estimate the effect of China's non-support on UNSC sanction success is specified as:

$$\text{logit}[P(\text{Success} = 1)] = 0.48 \; - \; 2.27\,\text{ChinaNS}, \tag{1}$$

where ChinaNS equals 1 when China abstains or vetoes a resolution and 0 when China votes in favor.

China's non-support for UNSC sanctions was found to be a modest determinant of UNSC sanction success, with a below 5-percent chance of it being an insignificant factor ($p = 0.0415$). Using predicted probabilities derived from this model, we estimate that when China supports a UNSC sanction, its chance of success is around 62 percent, while when China does not support a UNSC sanction, its chance of success drops to around 14 percent. The Model fit, as measured by a Tjur's R-squared, indicates that based on the difference in average predicted probabilities for UNSC sanction success and failure, around 9.2 percent of variation in UNSC sanction success is explained by China's non-support for the sanction. Therefore, China's non-support for a sanction is a limited predictor of sanction success.

Table 1: Effect of China's Non-Support on UNSC Sanction Success (Logistic Regression)

	Estimate	Std. Error	z	p
Intercept	0.4818	0.2775	1.736	$0.0826^{\dagger}$
China Non-Support	-2.2736	1.1152	-2.039	0.0415^{*}
Model Statistics				
Null deviance: 84.915 (df = 61)				
Residual deviance: 78.886 (df = 60)				
AIC: 82.886				
Tjur R^2: 0.092				

Significance: $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{\dagger}p < 0.10$

These results are heavily affected by China's overall willingness to support UNSC sanctions. Of the 57 resolutions imposing sanctions which we analyzed, China supported all but two of them (abstaining on those two). Out of these, there were 35 successful sanctions, and China supported 34 of them. Out of the remaining 22 unsuccessful sanctions, China supported 21. Of course, China did not support all 5 drafts threatening sanctions which it vetoed. Since China did not support only 7 of the 62 sanctions we analyzed, the model has fairly high uncertainty regarding the effect of China's non-support ($SE = 1.1152$), which inflated the p-value. More generally, out of the 364 non-vetoed resolutions from 1972-2023 containing sanctions which we identified, China supported 87 percent of them. Therefore, the effect of China's non-support on sanction success is obscured by the overwhelming presence of Chinese-supported sanctions among sanctions in general, and of Chinese-supported sanctions among those with defined success rates. Ultimately, China's non-support has an effect on UNSC sanction success almost entirely through China's vetoes, which have only occurred 19 times since China became a permanent member of the UNSC in 1972. Removing the 5 drafts containing sanctions vetoed by China from the data results in a statistically insignificant effect of China's non-support on UNSC sanction success ($p = 0.7381$, $SE = 1.4412$).

5 Discussion

China occupies a unique position within the P5, being neither committed to the LIO nor antagonistic to it, and so it can be swayed to support the LIO when it otherwise would not have. China is the only state which has the power to veto sanctions presented by the P3, may find it advantageous to do so, and yet can reasonably be persuaded to support a sanction. In defining how UNSC sanctions upholding the LIO can succeed, it is crucial to analyze China in particular, to observe the degree to which its non-support (abstentions or vetoes) for UNSC sanctions upholding the international law or human rights suborders of the LIO matters for the success of these sanctions.

We conclude that, overall, China agrees with the P3 quite often regarding the Liberal International Order, and so China largely adheres to the LIO. Particularly, we cannot conclude that China is more adherent to the security or the human rights suborders, as China is roughly equally adherent to both. This defies our assumption of a nuanced Chinese relationship with the LIO, as this relationship is not characterized by a greater adherence to some parts of the LIO over other parts. China seems to assess the LIO holistically as it pertains to the security and human rights suborders. China diverges most from the LIO in opposing sanctions which are against its specific interests in states such as Syria, Somalia, and Libya. When China does veto, it is always in nonadherence to the LIO.

Among the P3 states, China agrees most often with France, and least often with the US, but the difference is very small. The most liberal states have shared interests as a bloc, the least liberal states do as well, and the least liberal states have shared interests which are fairly divergent from those of the most liberal states. This pattern is somewhat more pronounced for sanctions upholding the security suborder than sanctions upholding the human rights suborder, and is most pronounced for sanctions over Syria, Sudan, Somalia, and Libya, in that order. China's non-support has a modest negative effect on UNSC sanction success, which is limited by China's overall willingness to support UNSC sanctions regardless of if they culminate in success or failure. China usually abstains on sanctions which it does not support, but it only truly has an effect on UNSC sanction success through its vetoes. Overall, it is necessary for the P3 to try to avoid incurring a veto from China if it wants its sanctions to succeed, but China will most likely support their sanctions, and there are many more considerations which matter for UNSC sanction success as well.

Future work could also try to deal with selection issues more rigorously. Some would-be UNSC sanctions never reach a vote because sponsors anticipate Chinese (and/or Russian) opposition. While the high ratio of Chinese abstentions relative to vetoes historically suggests many drafts still reach the floor, anticipatory effects can operate earlier—via text dilution, issue parking, or committee holds. Future work could examine the drafting duration and

changes to the resolution prior to votes. In other cases, when the UNSC cannot reach consensus (e.g., Syria), the US and EU pursue unilateral or coalition sanctions to uphold the LIO. If this occurs often, the set of UNSC sanction votes may not reflect LIO compliance. Comparing outcomes across these "UNSC-blocked" cases can reveal whether multilateral legitimacy (with PRC on board) is integral to effectiveness—or whether robust unilateral regimes can substitute. Further work could be done to assess if these alternative sanctions regimes systematically underperform on compliance relative to comparable UNSC cases, which may strengthen the claim that Chinese participation materially raises effectiveness. Finally, as China's global interests expand and U.S.–China rivalry intensifies, non-support (abstention/veto) of UNSC sanctions votes may increase, especially as the set of Chinese political interests and client states grow over time. Time-varying models could be used to predicting PRC support vs. non-support, with break points around plausible rivalry inflection years.

From here, there are multiple vantage points by which future research could elaborate upon the conditions which make China's non-support for UNSC sanctions more impactful for their success. An expansion of the number of cases with defined success ratings would enable findings on how significant China's non-support is for sanction success in different stages of China's evolution as a permanent member of the UNSC. Degrees of support and non-support for UNSC sanctions could also be derived from China's deliberations before voting and the explanations of its votes offered after voting. This could then be used to find whether the strength of China's support or non-support is a major factor in how significant China's behavior is for UNSC sanctions success. Accounting for the type of sanction (import restriction, export restriction, arms embargo, etc.) could also be useful for observing whether some types of sanctions are more dependent on China's support to succeed when compared to others.

Future research could also expand upon our measure of China's adherence to the LIO. China's adherence to the LIO could be evaluated with more nuance through the analysis of

its voting similarity to the P3 over other suborders of the LIO, possibly including economic and environmental suborders pertaining to free trade and conservation efforts, respectively. The definition of China's adherence to the LIO could also be refined through a method which analyzes vote similarity based on static principles of the LIO referenced in the language of China's voting decisions, rather than tying adherence to the LIO to alignment with the P3. Adherence by China to the LIO could additionally be measured not just in terms of its voting behavior on the UNSC, but also in its trade behavior, its level of coercion towards other states, the reasons for its coercion towards other states, and its level of respect for human rights within its borders. This measure of adherence would benefit from an analysis of China's vote similarity in each of the stages of its evolution as a permanent member of the UNSC.

Setting aside the growing number of areas where the US has itself been riding roughshod over the LIO in recent years, most notably on the World Trade Organization, future US foreign policy should not throw the baby out with the bathwater by treating China as a blanket spoiler and discounting the substantial record of Chinese cooperation on UNSC sanctions. On important nonproliferation cases such Iran and North Korea, Beijing's interests often converge with Washington's, and Chinese support has been pivotal for building broad, enforceable coalitions in the past. Overreliance on unilateral or secondary sanctions that target Chinese firms risks hardening opposition and shrinking the space for cooperation; prioritizing coordinated UNSC action preserves leverage where it matters most.

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